5 | South Asia's Nuclear Present and Future

In chapter 4, we discuss nuclear weapons' impact on the South Asian strategic environment from the late 1980s through 2002. According to Ganguly, Pakistan sought during this period to exploit various internal conflicts within India, especially those in the states of Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir. Though Pakistani adventurism contributed to regional tensions, war did not break out between the two antagonists. Nuclear weapons, most assuredly, did not contribute to these tensions and, in considerable measure, helped in preventing them from escalating into full-scale war. Even when a conflict did occur in 1999, the mutual possession of nuclear weapons played a crucial role in containing the scope and dimensions of the war. India did respond forcefully to the Pakistani Kargil intrusions in 1999 but scrupulously kept the conflict confined to the region where the initial incursions had occurred. Ganguly contends that in the absence of nuclear weapons the war would have broadened in scope and become more sanguinary.

Kapur argues that the years from the late 1980s through 2002 were consistent with the expectations of strategic pessimism. As Pakistan acquired a nuclear capability, it began a pattern of provocative behavior, ranging from large-scale support for the Kashmir insurgency to outright seizure of Indian territory. Pakistan used its burgeoning nuclear capacity as a shield against full-scale Indian retaliation and as a means of attracting international attention to the Kashmir dispute. Forceful Indian responses resulted in escalating regional violence.

In this chapter, we discuss nuclear weapons' effects on the current regional security environment and speculate as to their likely impact